



18 | THE RIGHT PICK Ashok Vaswani has had a storied career with long stints at large global banks like Citigroup and Barclays

ing down these barriers”.

That’s precisely what the bank has set out to get ahead of. It is already transforming from a conventional institution where IT plays a back-end role, to one where tech and customer-centricity take the lead. And the bank has gathered a number of leaders to achieve this. For instance, Milind Nagnur, with stints at JP Morgan, Citibank and Wells Fargo, has been appointed CTO; former Amazon hand Bhavnish Lathia has joined as Chief of Customer Experience and Head of Technology; while Unilever veteran Rohit Bhasin has been roped in as Head of Retail Liabilities Product and Chief Marketing Officer. Bhaskar Kumar, having worked at GE Capital, HSBC and Bajaj Finserv, has been appointed Chief Risk Officer. These professionals have further recruited top executives from global firms.

But, Vaswani will have to work under the careful oversight of the bank’s founder. “We anticipate

some changes in the bank’s strategies,” stated a report by discount broking firm StoxBox. Experts say Vaswani has got his work cut out when it comes to building bridges with the founder and the rest of the

KMB PLANS TO TRANSFORM INTO A BANK WHERE TECH AND CUSTOMER-CENTRICITY TAKE THE LEAD

senior management. The reason being the past examples—of ICICI Bank, HDFC Bank, Axis Bank, and IndusInd Bank—where the entry of a new CEO has led to many senior-level exits. Which behoves Vaswani to tread carefully.

In terms of business, Vaswani has

to step on the gas to build the mid-market book, an area where KMB plans to scale up. Similarly, the high-yielding unsecured book is also going up, while the risks are also high. Further, Vaswani is coming in at a time when the banking landscape is witnessing significant transformation, with the digital-first Jio Financial Services and the consolidation of public sector banks, set to reshape the industry.

While Uday Kotak’s departure has made the stock market uneasy, it would definitely keep an eye on Vaswani’s moves. Incidentally, risks also abound. “Banks face challenges in managing cybersecurity risk. They also have to adapt to geopolitical risk, unpredictable interest rates and bond yield fluctuations,” says Atul Parakh, CEO of share-trading app Bigul. But looking at Vaswani’s career, KMB looks firmly poised to execute its transformation. **BT**

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